LESSON 4.1 | Lesson notes

Primary and Foreign Keys

Overview

A primary key uniquely identifies each row, and many tables use an integer id that the database fills in automatically. A foreign key is a column that holds the primary key of a row in another table, linking the two. For example an orders table has a customer_id column that points to the customers table. The database can refuse a foreign key value that does not exist, which stops orders belonging to customers who were never created. Keys are what make a set of tables behave as one connected system.

Key points

- Part of: Designing Tables
- About 20 minutes
- Try the example yourself, then check it

How to use this handout

1. Read the overview first, then work through the key points in order.
2. Write down anything you are unsure about and ask in the course forum.
3. Use page 2 to plan your practice and keep notes.

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Practice checklist

- [ ] Read: Primary and Foreign Keys
- [ ] Try the example from the lesson
- [ ] Explain the main idea in your own words
- [ ] Answer the related questions
- [ ] Ask about anything unclear in the forum

My notes